> solely in the service of the kitchen. A like number, more handsomely equipped, ride on horseback. The remainder are carried by men in litters, of whom two thousand or three thousand are selected as his wives on condition that at his death they should voluntarily burn themselves with him, which is considered to be a great honour for them.

Conti describes temple rituals that are still performed today, but also a chariot festival in which ‘young women richly adorned … sing hymns to the god’, while others, ‘carried away by the fervor of their faith, cast themselves on the ground before the wheels, in order that they may be crushed to death—a mode of death which they say is very acceptable to their god’. One practice Conti had observed in central India likely also existed in the Vijayanagar Empire: ‘They have a vast number of slaves,’ he claims, ‘and the debtor who is insolvent is everywhere adjudged to be the property of his creditor’. This seems to describe bonded labour, then common in many parts of the world.

Conti writes that the people of Vijayanagar celebrate their weddings ‘with singing, feasting, and the sound of trumpets and flutes, for, with the exception of organs, all the other instruments in use among them for singing and playing are similar to our own’. He mentions a festival during which ‘they fix up within their temples, and on the outside of the roofs, an innumerable number of lamps of oil’, and another festival when ‘they sprinkle all passers-by, even the king and queen themselves, with saffron water, placed for that purpose by the wayside. This is received by all with much laughter’.

Conti tended to record more of the exotic or outlandish things, less so the charming or praiseworthy ones. His account also contains some odd observations, such as, ‘Pestilence is unknown among the Indians.’ In India, he met and married an Indian woman and had four children with her, all while travelling together. Sadly, two of the children and his wife died in a pestilence in Egypt, and Conti finally returned to Venice with his remaining children.

Abdur Razzaq

In 1443, Abdur Razzaq visited from Persia and was very impressed by Vijayanagar’s ‘enormous magnitude and population’ and its seven concentric walled fortifications of stone. The outermost, writes Razzaq, had